

Why Improvements Die

Implementing a solution is not the finish line, it is the halfway point.

Maria's Method

A clinic had chaotic patient intake, with the same questions asked repeatedly. A sharp nurse named Maria designed a smooth sequence so each piece of information was captured once, cleanly. Intake got faster, patients were happier, and errors dropped. It worked beautifully.

Writing In Sand

Then Maria went on maternity leave and within weeks intake slid back to the old way. Nobody decided to abandon her method, but it lived only in her head and the habits of people she coached. There was no document. It evaporated, as if it had never happened, and she had to start over.

Writing In Stone

Improvements die from simple entropy. Processes drift back the moment attention moves on, just as tides erase writing in sand. A simple SOP would have let cover staff follow Maria's sequence, so the gain survived her leave and the busy weeks. The knowledge becomes the property of the organization, not one memory.

Remember this

An improvement you cannot hand to a stranger and have them reproduce is one vacation away from death.